

MID-RANGE INTEL MOTHERBOARDS

Intel	SuperMicro	ASUS	AOpen
D865GBF	P4SPA+	P4S800-MX	MX4GER (E)
Intel 865G	Intel 865G	SiS 661FX	Intel 845 GE
Socket 478	Socket 478	Socket 478	Socket 478
P4 3.2 / 800	P4 3.2 / 800	P4 3.2 / 800	P4 3.06 / 533
DDR 400 / 4 / 4	DDR 400 / 4 / 4	DDR 400 / 2 / 2	DDR 333 / 2 / 2
ATX	ATX	Micro ATX	Micro ATX
✓ / ✓ / 8X	✓ / ✓ / 8X	✓ / ✓ / 8X	✓ / ✓ / 4X
6	5	3	3
✓	✓	✓	✓
✗	✗	✗	✗
8 / 4 / 4	8 / 6 / 2	6 / 2 / 4	6 / 4 / 2
✗ / ✗	✗ / ✓	✓ / ✗	✓ / ✗
2 / ✗	2 / ✗	✗ / ✗	✗ / ✗
✗	✓	✓ / ✓	✓ / ✓
✓	✓	✓	✓
2.5	3	2.5	1.5
✓ / ✓	✓ / ✓	✓ / ✓	✓ / ✓
✓	✓	✓	✓
272.2	270.1	221.2	235.9
335.89	335.76	212.9	387.17
573	476.8	489.1	521
28	28.1	26.9	24.9
21.5	21.9	20.9	20.7
70	72	77	91
3,395	3396	3,201	3,393
12,015	11950	10,774	11,428
4,944	4940	4,812	3,716
4,586	4448	3,553	3,087
2,795	2779	2,753	2,752
3,247	3268	3,267	3,370
4,894	4884	4,550	3,716
9,791 / 3,993	9,835 / 3,997	9,367 / 7,126	7,091
24,422 / 35,194	24,445 / 34,260	24,474 / 35,403	17,198
4,610	4368	2,931	2,452
4,609	4374	2,929	2,454
29,200	29,204	35,932	34,149
58.48	57.53	52.65	51.08
14.50	17.80	15.50	11.90
72.98	75.33	68.15	62.98
12.58	7.69	12.39	10.16
5,800	9,800	5,500	6,200
A+	B-	A+	B+

Intel's CSA based Gigabit controller enables you to transfer data at much greater speeds over the network than a normal Ethernet 100base-T controller. The ICH5 offers eight USB 2.0 ports to connect external USB devices for data transfer.

You also get a host of other frills from ASUS—the jack-sensing six-channel audio AD 1985 codec from Analog Devices. This codec senses what's plugged in the sound ports, and notifies you if a wrong connection is made. Tweak the BIOS to overclock the board. Intelligent management of cooling fans results in low noise.

Priced at Rs 18,500, the board offers good value for money, since it's priced much less than other workstation or server-class boards.



The Intel D865GBF walked away with the top honours with its superb all-round performance and decent features, coupled with the legendary stability that Intel offers



Gigabyte's GA-8iG1000MK packs in useful features and a performance that goes well with its terrific pricing. At Rs 5,900, it offers best value like no other motherboard in this range

of performance, the Intel 865GBF performed exceptionally in every test we threw at it. The AOpen MX45G-4DN also posted some good scores in the set of tests that it was put through and came a close second behind the Intel 865GBF.

Conclusion

The mid-range motherboards for the Intel platform are probably the most important; the boards in this section have the features of a high-end motherboard, but at more affordable prices. So if you are looking at setting up a multi-user PC, with a bare minimum system, with the intention of upgrading later, the best option is an 865-based board.

The Gigabyte GA-8iG1000MK board, with its good performance and equally good feature set, won the Best Value award. Another board you might consider is the P4P800-VM from ASUS, which was equally impressive. On the performance ground, nothing could beat the Intel 865GBF, but remember you can't overclock this board. Enthusiasts should opt for the AOpen MX45G-4DN, or the Gigabyte GA-81PE1000-L motherboard.